

Bollywood

Thus far, Bollywood has been known more for the antics of characters portrayed by actors such as Mithun Chakraborty and Rajnikant! We're used to seeing people leap up to the fourth floor of a building—backwards! People think nothing of a hero who can split a bullet on a blade and kill two baddies with one shot! It's cinema, it's supposed to be unbelievable!

However, more people are attempting to make serious, well-researched movies. Although we applaud their effort, we should also point out flaws in their research. Bollywood's version of a mish-mash of Hollywood's *Close Encounters of a Third Kind*, and *ET: The Extraterrestrial*, called *Koi... Mil Gaya*, stars Hrithik Roshan as a mentally challenged man. His father, a scientist devoted to finding extraterrestrial life-forms, invented various techniques of contacting alien life forms. One works! It's a computer that transmits sound to outer space—the sounds are very similar to what you'll hear when you watch *Close Encounters Of The Third Kind*, except that they're the holy word 'Om' in different notes!

What's hilarious is the 'computer' that Hrithik's father uses: it looks like an old oscilloscope was picked out from hospital trash and a small TV fitted into it. Then, someone used some Windows Media Player visualisations to try and make it look like the 'computer' was actually transmitting and receiving sound!

Though the computer only plays a small part in the story, it would have been nice for someone to actually dig up an old 486 and try



Above: These keys produce sounds; but what you don't see is the piano. Now why didn't they use that?

Below: The monitor used on the 'old' PC looks more like an oscilloscope than a monitor



and make the computer a little more believable!

Another recent Bollywood movie is *16 December*—it's about secret agents and spies for the Indian government looking to track down terrorists. Keeping with the tradition of portraying hackers as young geniuses, this movie has a hacker who looks no older than 10. He's a Mac user as well!

There's a scene in the movie where he's

The year 1995 did not belong to Sandra Bullock in *The Net*, not as far as we are concerned. Angelina Jolie, in *Hackers*, took the baker home with her!

The plot is about hackers in 1995 who stumble upon a huge plot to swindle money from a corporation, and somewhere along the line, the plot involves the American Secret Service. Billions of dollars at stake? Nope, not quite; all this racket is created over the attempted theft of a mere 25 million dollars. If anything, here's one aspect of the movie that goes against Hollywood norms of exaggeration!

Coming back to goofs and unbelievable technology... we're not quite sure where to begin with this one!

The plot involves a hacker called 'Ice Cool' who creates a virus in 1988 at the tender age of 11, a virus that crashes 1,507 computers - surely a huge deal in 1988! It's 1995 now, and he's finally allowed to touch computers again - and of course, his first act in the movie is to hack a television station. Here he meets (in the virtual world) another hacker called 'Acid Burn', who promptly manages to terminate his connection... so far so good.

However, this is where technology takes a backseat and Hollywood effects kick in.

Throughout the movie, you see unbelievable displays on computer screens, a lot of useless jargon such as RISC, PCI-BUS, and so on being thrown at you out of context, but by far, the juiciest of all blunders is when *Acid Burn* (Jolie) shows off her new laptop, which is a Mac, to Ice Cool, and boasts of it having a P6 chip! Were the writers of this movie soothsayers? Apple just recently announced its plans to use Intel's chips for the first time!

As for the rest of the movie, we'll let the screenshots do the talking!

Independence Day

Yes, there was computer technology used in the plot of *Independence Day*; though most of us were busy oohing and aahing at the effects, some computer nerds were asking, "So how exactly does Jeff Goldblum interface with Alien technology?"

It takes the best hackers and virus writers on the planet a good deal of time to come up with a virus for, say, Windows XP. In order to find a flaw in an operating system, you need to be an expert in that system! And that's for just finding a flaw - writing a virus that's undetectable and exploits that flaw is another ballgame altogether!

